



A license plate reader device on the BYU campus. The devices track license plates and car movements. (Maya Taylor)

Citizens of Provo have mixed feelings toward the city's contract with the private security company Flock Safety.

On Jan. 13, Dallin Flake, a Provo resident, shared a public comment during the Provo City Council Meeting.

"I am here tonight to urge the council to terminate the city's contract with Flock Safety," Flake said.



Dallin Flake speaks at the Provo City Council Meeting Jan. 13. He voiced concerns about the city's contract with Flock Safety. (Courtesy of Provo City Council)

Many cities in the U.S., including Provo, have contracts with Flock Safety. Their most prominent security device is its automated license plate reader, which reads plates and identifies cars using artificial intelligence.

While many police officers have shared that [the use of Flock Safety devices](#) has allowed for more efficient police work, Flake and others believe the products raise privacy concerns and constitute a breach of the Fourth Amendment.

Flake first became aware of the conversation surrounding Flock Safety when watching a [YouTube video uploaded by Ben Jordan](#).

"What Flock is doing differently than just a regular security camera that an institution like a city or private institution might run is that it is connected with the rest of the network," Flake said.

Multiple cities, including Santa Cruz, California; Flagstaff, Arizona; Springfield, Missouri; and Cambridge, Massachusetts, are terminating their contracts with Flock Safety.

Flake made it clear that he does not "advocate lawlessness," but rather wants "more adherence to the constitution."

"I'm just a regular citizen. I've never been in government. I have nothing special, but I know that I have my right to privacy of movement, and so it's very concerning to me," Flake said.

Adam Baker, director of the Security Operations Center at BYU, addressed concerns over security and privacy.

"There is a natural tension between security and privacy," he said.

Baker explained this tension is partially due to ongoing technological developments.

“So, how do you still protect people and protect their rights as the technology becomes easier and easier to obtain? That’s the natural tension,” Baker said.

In terms of public institutions contracting private companies, Baker said the practice is standard.

“The U.S. government is really not good at creating things like software. They’re too big. They take too long, they’re way too expensive,” he said. “Working in forensics on the government side, we were using the top-of-the-line software that was available on the civilian side; it’s the same software that the Department of Justice uses.”



A security camera hangs on campus housing. Various security devices are used across the BYU campus. (Maya Taylor)

Others, such as BYU student David Penigar, shared their feelings on the security controversy.

“I feel like we’re already kind of tracked, so I think security is great, but I’m also mostly indifferent,” Penigar said.

He added that tracking technology should only be used for safety. “Obviously, I don’t think it’s right to sell information,” he said.



A student enters a car in a BYU parking lot. License plate readers check if cars are registered correctly. (Maya Taylor)

It is unknown what course of action the Provo City Council will take regarding its contract. According to Flake, city councilors have responded to his emails, and one expressed interest in discussing the matter with other council members in the next council work meeting.

Flake plans to continue attending city council meetings to encourage the city to terminate the contract.

“You have a way bigger impact on what your city does than what your state, or certainly what the federal government does,” Flake said.

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